

Limitations

Grad Cafe doesn't sample graduate applicants. It samples the ones who chose to post. Nobody is recruited, nothing is checked, and no one follows up with the people who never came back. So, every number I found describes whoever thought their result was worth typing into a form. Two things filter that group, and both push the same way. First, you have to post at all, which usually means you have news worth sharing, good or bad, and that you run in the online circles where the site gets passed around. Those circles lean hard toward computer science, engineering, the sciences, and North American schools. Then you decide, box by box, how much to say. I can see that second filter in my own data. 29,483 entries give a GPA. Only 3,769 give a GRE Quantitative score. That puts the GRE averages in Question 3 on under 8% of the table. A gap that big doesn't cancel out. If people who scored badly are more likely to skip the box, then my average is really the average among people willing to post a score, and it reads high. Question 5 has the same problem. Someone rejected everywhere has little reason to come back and update a profile. Someone holding an offer has every reason. So, I can't read 40.74% as the odds that an application works.

The data isn't just thin, it's wrong in places, and the math carries the errors straight through. Grad Cafe checks nothing an applicant types. When I counted, 2,316 of the 3,769 GRE Quantitative scores, 61% of them turned out to be impossible on a scale that runs 130 to 170. They aren't random junk. The GRE scores Verbal and Quantitative from 130 to 170 each, then reports a combined total from 260 to 340, and 2,264 of the bad values, 97.75%, land inside that second range. I ran a second check. Of those rows, 1,675 also lists a verbal score on its own. Subtract it and what's left averages 165.26, back inside the legal range, within a point of the scores that were fine all along. So, a row showing `gre = 323` next to `gre_v = 161` isn't a typo. That person answered a different question than the label implies. The damage is big. Question 3 puts the average GRE Quantitative at 261.45, which nobody has ever scored. Cut it down to values the scale allows and the same column averages 165.74. Analytical Writing does the same thing, pushed from 4.33 to 9.17 by people typing 99.99 into a box that stops at 6. What strikes me is how correct the wrong number is. 261.45 is added up right, rounded right, and anyone who runs my query gets it. It still says nothing about GRE scores. It describes a text box. A query is only worth as much as the match between what a field is called and what people actually typed into it, and on anonymous data I have to test that match instead of assuming it. So, I reported the answers the questions literally ask for, and put the size of their distortion right beside them, instead of quietly swapping in clean figures and letting them pass as sound.